EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

Why Does the Torah Promise Rain, Not Heaven? Nine Answers

Emunot VeDeot, Essay 9:2

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 9 (Olam HaBa, The World to Come), Chapter 2 (continued), with the survey of the Rishonim in the Abarbanel

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 15 September 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where We Are in Essay 9

Essay 9 is about **עולם הבא**, the World to Come. For Rav Saadia, Olam HaBa comes **after** Mashiach, after תחיית המתים, after the rebuilding of the Beit HaMikdash. After all of that, a new world is created. The details of that world (body and soul, what will be there, when it will be, time and so on) come in **Chapters 5 to 11**, the end of the essay. For now Saadia is still establishing **the concept itself**: where do we get the idea that there is an afterlife at all?

- **Chapter 1:** six **logical arguments** that there must be an afterlife.
- **Chapter 2:** six **proofs from the Torah**. Yitzchak went up to the Akeidah even though, if there is no afterlife, what would he gain? Moshe Rabbeinu, Eliyahu and Elisha could perform miracles for others but could not do them for themselves.

Then Saadia threw in the question that fills this whole shiur:

Lovely, you've proved to me from logic, and you've proved to me from the Torah, that there is a concept of Olam HaBa. **So why is there no explicit mention of it in the Torah?**

Saadia, the Rabbi stressed, was **the first person to ask this question**. He gives two answers:

1. **It can be known by reason.** The afterlife can be deduced by pure logic, and the Torah does not need to spell out what reason already tells us. Reward and punishment **in this world**, however, is something the Torah does need to tell us.
2. **The Torah deals with the now.** It speaks about the present and the foreseeable future. What comes after will come after.

"I don't know how convinced you are with these answers," the Rabbi said, but those are Saadia's. Since Saadia was the first to ask but "certainly not the last," every century of Rishonim returned to the question. The **Abarbanel**, writing at the end of the 15th century, right at the end of the period of the Rishonim, collected **seven answers** from them. There are more, and the Rabbi added two later ones at the end. Last week covered the first two.

Answer 1 (Recap): The Rambam, "The Wrong Question"

The Rambam's answer, which the Rabbi had also discussed in his Tuesday Rambam shiur the week before, is that the question is a **non-starter**. The question assumes the Torah mentions reward in this world but not in the next. According to the Rambam, **the Torah does not mention reward and punishment at all, neither in this world nor in the next.** It does not want reward to be the motive for observing the Torah and the mitzvot. We are meant to do it **לשמה**.

What about Ki Tavo, which had just been read that Shabbat, with its blessings and curses? The Rabbi noted how excited people get about it. They read the curses quietly and nobody wants to be called up. At a Shabbat Chatan he had just attended "there was a whole tumult" over who would be called up for which aliyah.

For the Rambam, none of it is reward and punishment. The blessings are **supports** and the curses are **impediments**:

- When you do the will of Hashem, doing the truth because it is the truth, Hashem blesses you so that you can carry out that intention and pursue your goals. You will be blessed in your field and your house and you will not be ill, because "if you have illness, how can you study? How can you devote yourself to developing your character, developing your intellect, developing your identity?"
- If you want to go down the path of not treating the mitzvot as important, then Hashem will not even give you the means to care about them.

בדרך שאדם רוצה לילך בה מוליכין אותו (Makkot 10b)

In the way a person wants to go, he is led.

"You want to go on the path of developing yourself? I'll help you. I'll bless you, and you'll be able to focus. You don't want to go on that path? I'll put impediments in your path as well."

Answer 2 (Recap): The Ibn Ezra, "Too Deep for the Masses"

The Torah speaks about reward in this world, and only hints at the next, because Olam HaBa is **too deep and too complex** to explain to the masses. The Torah speaks about what is practical and tangible, what people can relate to.

This is close to an idea the Rambam uses often (familiar to those in the Tuesday shiur): the Torah and Chazal sometimes say things **for the masses**, who need something concrete. But the Ibn Ezra differs from the Rambam on the main point. For the Ibn Ezra, reward and punishment in this world **is real**. It is simply not the main thing, and the afterlife is hinted at because the majority of people need that.

Answer 3: The Ramban, "Reason Already Tells You"

The Abarbanel brings the third answer in the name of the **Ramban**, and it is "basically identical to the first answer of Saadia." The survival of the soul after death, and the spiritual reward and punishment that go with it, are **demanded by human nature and by reason**. You do not need religion to tell you that your actions have consequences. Philosophically, it has to be so.

The Torah is not a book written to tell you about what follows naturally. What it promises are things **above nature**, which come from השגחה עליונה, Hashem's direct providence. The Abarbanel's example is the

pasuk in Behar about Shemittah:

וצויתי את ברכתי לכם בשנה הששית ועשת את התבואה לשלש השנים (Vayikra 25:21)

I will command My blessing for you in the sixth year, and it will produce enough for three years.

"These are things which are beyond comprehension, beyond nature, that you're going to have produce of one year to last for three years." Similarly, the punishments for eating forbidden foods are consequences in this world, and these too are beyond the natural order.

As the Ramban put it, the promises of the covenant are all **דברים נסיים**, miracles. Plant a field and normally you get one year of produce; supernaturally you get three. That is what the Torah needs to mention: the places where Hashem changes the course of this world. The reward of the soul in the next world follows from the nature of the soul and **אינו בדרך פלא**, it is not a wonder. It is obvious, so the Torah did not need to write it. The Abarbanel says the Ramban considered this the correct answer.

Albo's objection

Some commentators had a problem with this. **Rabbi Yosef Albo**, in the **Sefer Halkarim**, says: I don't understand. The Torah mentions plenty of things that reason already knows. His example is **בחירה**, free will. Free will is a logical imperative, "because if there's no free will, our whole Torah falls apart." The Rabbi said he always makes this point on Rosh Hashanah and Yom Kippur: if you don't believe you can change, there is no point to them. And yet the Torah emphasises it: **ובחרת בחיים**.

So the Torah does mention things that can be deduced, and to say it left out Olam HaBa because it is obvious is, says Albo, a weak answer. The Rabbi added two more points:

1. It is clearly **not** obvious. "Nowadays not everyone believes in Olam HaBa."
2. Even if it were obvious, why would the Torah then write nothing about it and focus only on this world?

"For me personally, I much prefer the first two answers so far, of the Rambam or of the Ibn Ezra. This I find difficult." But it is the answer of the Ramban and the first answer of Saadia, "and therefore it has weight."

Answer 4: The Kuzari, "First Prove the Medicine Works"

The fourth answer comes from the **Kuzari**. It is not entirely clear who wrote the Kuzari, the Rabbi noted, but we assume it was **Rabbi Yehudah HaLevi** in the 12th century. The book is a dialogue between the king of the Khazars and the Rabbi, and the king asks this question.

The Kuzari's parable is a **doctor**. For you to listen to a doctor, he first has to prove that he is effective. He gives you a small medicine, shows you it works, and only then gives you the real treatment you need.

So too with Hashem. If the covenant in Bechukotai and Ki Tavo had been all about spiritual promises, **Bnei Yisrael would not have believed them**, because the principle of providence had not yet been proven to them. We were only just entering the covenant. "I haven't seen any credible evidence of the consequences of my actions." So Hashem first promised them **things they could perceive with their senses**: that He runs the world and gives good to the good and bad to the bad, here and now. Then they would believe that everything is in His hand, **כחומר ביד היוצר**, like clay in the hand of the potter. The punishments and rewards that can be felt in this world become the clearest evidence of השגחה פרטית.

The Rabbi's analogy: an investment

"Let me give you a much simpler analogy." Imagine trying to convince someone to invest with you. If you say, "Invest with me and in fifty years you'll be a billionaire," he will say: maybe, maybe not, you haven't shown me anything. But if you say, "In one month I'll make you 500 pounds," fine, let's do a deal. If that works, next you can talk about 1,000 and 10,000 pounds, and then about billions in fifty years' time.

Hashem is making a deal between us and Him. At the start, the objectives have to be ones "where you can meet them and I can see them now, in the next month or two."

Why there were more miracles then

This also answers a question people often ask: why were there so many more miracles in the days of the Torah? The Red Sea, the well, water from a rock. "When was the last time anyone here in the last 1,000, 2,000 years saw a rock giving water?" One approach is that then there was גילוי פנים and now there is הסתר פנים. But the simpler answer is the Kuzari's: **that was the beginning**. We had just become a nation, with centuries and millennia ahead of us. At the start of a covenant, Hashem puts things straightforwardly and openly.

Connection to Saadia's second answer

The Rabbi suggested this is really **Saadia's second answer**, that the Torah deals with the now. You can read them separately, but they tie together. Think of the people's position: "We're entering Canaan, we've become a nation with these new laws. Starting fresh. We're not coming off a tradition of thousands of years." What they need to know is: will we have water? Will there be famine? The covenant can be verified through the now, not through an afterlife thousands of years away.

Answer 5: The Abarbanel, "Weaning Us Off Avodah Zarah"

The fifth answer is quite similar to the fourth. The Abarbanel attributes it to Saadia Gaon, but as the Rabbi pointed out, it is not in Saadia ("maybe he had a different version"), so the Rabbi called it **the answer of the Abarbanel himself**.

The Rambam's principle

The Rambam does not give this answer, since for him the question never begins. But it uses a principle the Rambam uses throughout the Moreh Nevuchim: **many mitzvot are designed to wean Bnei Yisrael off avodah zarah**. The Torah was given into a world of polytheism and paganism.

- **Meat and milk.** The Rishonim give many reasons. The Rambam's is very simple: it was a pagan practice.
- **Peot and shaving with a razor.** This is what the idolatrous priests did.
- The Rabbi said that well over a hundred mitzvot are connected by the Rambam to avodah zarah.

Most famously, and the Rambam was "heavily criticised for this," he held that **the korbanot** of Vayikra (olah, chatat, asham, minchah and all their details) are only **בדיעבד**. Ideally we go direct to Hashem; what is the point of bringing an animal and killing it? But people living in a culture of avodah zarah psychologically needed a physical form of worship. Without korbanot they would go and sacrifice to idols on private altars. So the Torah says: sacrifice, but only to the One God, in the Beit HaMikdash. Will there be korbanot in the future? "That's a big discussion." The Rambam did codify the laws of korbanot for the future, but that is for another time.

Applied to reward

Idolatry offered **quick, easy rewards for small investments**. Pray to this idol and you'll get a son; to that one and you'll get rain; to another and you'll get money and health. The pagan priests promised physical results and held special services at special times to bring rain or increase produce, since they believed all of it was governed by the stars and the celestial bodies.

When Hashem wanted to bring us back to pure faith, He gave us His Torah and forbade their forms of worship. He then had to tell us: **don't think that by giving up those services you will lose the physical goods the idols promised you.** The Abarbanel quotes the words of the women in Yirmiyahu:

ומן אז חדלנו לקטר למלכת השמים... חסרנו כל (Yirmiyahu 44:18)

Since we stopped offering incense to the Queen of Heaven, we have lacked everything.

"We don't want that to be." It is the opposite: when we distance ourselves from avodah zarah we come close to Hashem and have more success. But people were used to hearing that serving the idol brings reward and neglecting it brings punishment, so Hashem gave them an equivalent. "It's like the korbanot." Really, the main thing is reward in the next world, and that is hinted at in the Torah. But while Hashem was making us into a people and taking us off avodah zarah, the people's worry was: if I stop serving, I'll lose my rain, my health, my livelihood. Hashem promises: no. Serve Me, and you will have them.

Answer 6: The Kuzari Again, "Body and Soul Together"

The sixth answer is also from the Kuzari. "To be honest, I don't fully understand this answer," the Rabbi said, but he explained it to the best of his understanding.

Of course the real reward is spiritual: the soul's delight in true intellect and in cleaving to Hashem. That **is** mentioned in the covenant, though briefly, in Bechukotai:

ונתתי משכני בתוככם... והתהלכתי בתוככם והייתי לכם לאלהים (Vayikra 26:11-12)

I will place My dwelling among you... I will walk among you and be your God.

The Kuzari's point is that this closeness to Hashem comes **together with the body** as well. "The body will follow the soul, and the soul follows the body." Already in this world a person can get a taste of the reward of the next. The Gemara's blessing **עולמך תראה בחייך**, "may you see your world in your lifetime," means experiencing a little of the afterlife already here. The Gemara also says that Shabbat is one sixtieth of Olam HaBa.

But for the body to enjoy that spiritual reward together with the soul, the body has to be healthy and prosperous. That is why the Torah promises physical blessings. "There is a mention of the spiritual, but the main one is the physical, because the physical needs to be there to enjoy the spiritual, not just in the next world, but already in this world." The Rabbi added, "I'm not convinced," and moved on.

Answer 7: The Ikarim, "A Covenant With a Nation"

The seventh and final answer in the Abarbanel comes from **Rabbi Yosef Albo**, "the Spanish philosopher from the 1400s," in the Sefer HaIkarim. The Rabbi called it "another very good answer."

The covenant of Bechukotai and Ki Tavo is made with **the community, the tzibbur, the nation as a whole**. Its rewards and punishments are **national**, not individual. Rain, produce, victory over enemies: these cannot be given to one person and withheld from his neighbour. "If there's rain, there's rain for you

and me, we live next to each other. If we're going to beat our enemies, it's for you and me together." The covenant was with all of Am Yisrael, so it speaks about what belongs to the people as a whole.

אמנם ייעודי הנפש אינם אלא לכל איש ואיש מישראל בפרטות

But the promises of the soul are only for each individual in Israel, one by one.

Spiritual reward in the afterlife is individual, "tailor-made for each person," as the series has seen many times. A national covenant can only be expressed in physical terms. "I think that's a very convincing answer."

Two Later Answers

The Ramchal: it cannot be described

Rabbi Moshe Chaim Luzzatto gives an answer similar to the Ibn Ezra's but different, and the Rabbi thought the Rambam would probably agree with it. The Torah does not elaborate on Olam HaBa because **it is not something that can be talked about**.

עין לא ראתה אלהים זולתך (Yeshayahu 64:3)

No eye has seen it, O God, except You.

"How can I give you a list of blessings and curses of what Olam HaBa is going to be, when the whole concept is something unfathomable for the human mind?" A human being in a physical body cannot grasp it, as discussed at length in the previous Tuesday's Rambam shiur. So the Torah references it but does not expand on it.

Rabbi Sacks: do not neglect this world

The final answer is from **Rabbi Sacks**. The Rabbi was not sure whether it was his own, "but I think there's beauty to it," and called it "a very important outlook on life."

Look through history at how the Jewish people have always tried to **progress the world**. Look at Israel today: its advances in science, technology and medicine, including a new cancer treatment from Israeli scientists announced a couple of weeks before. "We are leading the world in many fields despite the tiny percentage of our population." That is because, although we believe that Olam HaBa is the ultimate, it **cannot come at the expense of living the best life in this world**.

When we say **ויכלו השמים והארץ וכל צבאם** we become partners in מעשה בראשית. Hashem created this beautiful world, and we have a duty to take part in its creation and development with Him.

If a religion places all its emphasis on the afterlife, people forget about this world. "Let's be frank here": the jihadi philosophy of "I'll commit suicide, I'll be a suicide bomber, because I have an afterlife" stems from a **negation of this world**. Jews and Muslims both believe in an afterlife, with very different understandings of what it is. But Judaism holds that this life is also important, "perhaps as important." Had the Torah focused too much on the afterlife, we would neglect our role and purpose here. So Hashem told us: focus on this world, make the most of it, **לתקן עולם במלכות שדי**, bring Hashem into the physical world in which we live.

Summary: Nine Answers

#	Source	Why the Torah promises this world and only hints at the next
1	**Rambam**	Wrong question. The Torah mentions no reward at all, only supports and impediments
2	**Ibn Ezra**	Olam HaBa is too deep for the masses, who need something tangible
3	**Ramban** (= Saadia's first answer)	Reward in the next world follows from reason and nature; only the supernatural rewards of this world need stating
4	**Kuzari** (close to Saadia's second answer)	A new covenant needs promises that can be verified now
5	**Abarbanel**	To wean the people off avodah zarah, which promised immediate physical rewards
6	**Kuzari**	The body must flourish to share with the soul in the spiritual reward, even in this world
7	**Ikarim** (Rabbi Yosef Albo)	The covenant is national, and national reward can only be physical; spiritual reward is individual
8	**Ramchal**	Olam HaBa cannot be described: עין לא ראתה
9	**Rabbi Sacks**	Too much focus on the next world would make us neglect this one

Saadia gave two of the nine. "Each one of you will have different preferences." The Rabbi's own:

- **The Rambam's is the best**, "because the Rambam isn't giving an answer. The Rambam is saying there's no question at all. You misunderstood the whole concept of what the Torah is saying."
- There is also a lot of truth to the **Ibn Ezra**, that it is too deep, together with the **Ramchal**, that it cannot be described.
- And the other answers add the focus on this world, the national covenant and the present.

Looking Ahead

The Rabbi stopped early rather than start Chapter 3, which is "one big topic" that he wanted to do in one go. There would be no shiur the following Monday because of **Rosh Hashanah**; the series would resume two weeks later, during the Aseret Yemei Teshuvah.

- **Chapter 3:** further proofs from the Torah, with many pesukim that each need investigating.
- **Chapter 4:** sources for Olam HaBa from Chazal and the tradition.
- **Chapters 5 to 11:** "the meat" of what Olam HaBa is. Saadia asks about thirteen questions on its nature: Will we be able to see each other there? What is the nature of the reward and of the punishment? Will there be time? Will there be mitzvot and aveirot? "He's the first one to ask any of these questions."

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